New volunteer orientation · Cedar Falls

Paws & People

Every animal that walks through our doors leaves better than it arrived — because of you.

What we'll cover in today's orientation.

01 Who we are and what we do

02 The animals you'll help care for

03 How to get started — your first three steps

04 Your first-shift checklist

05 Who to call when you need help

Welcome — you just joined a team of 340 people who show up for animals.

Paws & People is a no-kill shelter and adoption center on Cedar Falls' east side. We take in dogs, cats, and the occasional rabbit nobody else will, and we keep them safe until the right family arrives.

- We've run on volunteers and donations since 2009 — no city funding, no shortcuts.
- Most of what gets done here, gets done by someone exactly like you.

Our mission is simple — no healthy or treatable animal is ever turned away.

Last year we cared for 2,100 animals and found homes for 1,650 of them. The rest are still with us, getting medical care, training, and the daily attention that makes them adoptable.

- "No-kill" only works when enough hands share the daily load — feeding, walking, comforting.
- An animal that's walked, brushed, and talked to shows better and goes home faster.

The animals you'll meet are mostly ordinary pets who hit a hard stretch.

On any given day we house around 90 animals. Few are here because something is wrong with them — most arrived because a family moved, lost a home, or simply couldn't keep up.

- Roughly 60 dogs and 30 cats, plus the occasional rabbit, guinea pig, or bonded pair.
- Every animal is vetted, vaccinated, and temperament-noted before it ever meets a volunteer.

Impact · last 12 months

What volunteers like you made possible last year.

Cedar Falls shelter, July 2025 – June 2026.

1,650
ANIMALS ADOPTED

340
ACTIVE VOLUNTEERS

18,000
SHIFT HOURS GIVEN

11
AVERAGE DAYS TO ADOPTION

A typical day here runs on three shifts — and every shift needs hands.

The shelter opens at 7 a.m. and closes after the evening clean. Pick the shifts that fit your week — there's no minimum.

- Morning `7–10 a.m.` — feeding, kennel cleaning, and the first dog walks of the day.
- Midday `11 a.m.–2 p.m.` — adoption-floor support, cat socializing, laundry.
- Evening `4–7 p.m.` — final walks, enrichment, and settling everyone for the night.

Why your hours matter

11 days

is how long the average animal waits for a home — every walk and brush you give shortens it.

> *I came to walk one dog on a Saturday. Two years later it's the best part of my week, every week.*

— RENATA VOSS, WEEKEND VOLUNTEER SINCE 2024

Three steps to your first shift.

STEP 01

Orientation

Complete this session and sign the volunteer agreement and liability waiver.

STEP 02

Shadow shift

Pair with an experienced volunteer for one two-hour shift to learn the routine.

STEP 03

Solo ready

Pick up your badge and start booking your own shifts in the volunteer portal.

Most people are booking solo shifts within their first two weeks.

There's no test and no rush. You'll learn the routine by doing it alongside someone who's done it a hundred times, and you move to solo shifts the moment you feel ready — not before.

- Bring questions, not experience — every coordinator started exactly where you are now.
- If a task isn't for you, say so; there's always another way to help the animals.

Booking a shift takes about a minute, all from your phone.

Once your badge is active, the volunteer portal shows every open slot for the next two weeks. Claim one, swap one, or cancel — just give us four hours' notice so we can backfill the floor.

- Set a recurring slot and it auto-books each week; you'll get a text reminder the night before.
- No-shows happen — tell Priya and we'll never make it a thing.

Before your first shift, make sure you've got these.

- [x] Signed volunteer agreement
- [x] Completed this orientation
- [-] Shadow shift scheduled — Book online
- [ ] Closed-toe shoes and a water bottle
- [ ] Emergency contact on file
- [~] ~~Animal-handling certification~~ — ~~Not needed yet~~

A few house rules that keep both you and the animals safe.

These aren't bureaucracy — every one comes from something we learned the hard way, and they become second nature fast.

- Never enter a kennel with a red card on the door without a staff member present.
- Wash hands between animals, and always sign in and out so we know who's on the floor.
- If an animal frightens you, step back and call a coordinator — that's the right move, not a failure.

Who to call when you need help.

Volunteer scheduling — Priya Anand, Coordinator

Shift changes, no-shows, and badge questions — text or email anytime.

Animal care questions — Dr. Lin Okafor, Vet tech

On site weekdays; ask before handling any flagged animal.

Adoption floor — Marcus Reyes, Lead

Pairs visitors with animals — loop him in before introducing a dog to a family.

After-hours emergencies — Front desk line

Injuries, escapes, or anything urgent — call first, then find the nearest staff.

You don't have to wait to feel useful — here's what helps most this month.

We're heading into our busiest adoption season, and a few gaps would make an outsized difference right now.

- Saturday morning dog walkers — our most-needed and most-loved slot.
- Cat socializers for the shy ones who need patience to show their best.
- Adoption-event helpers for the two pop-up events we host each month.

Priya Anand · Volunteer Coordinator · priya@pawsandpeople.example

Welcome to the team — the animals are lucky to have you.